

Chapter 141_1 - Qiu'er

After hearing those four words, Old Qiuguo's previously cloudy eyes became sharp. She pushed open the coffin lid and shakily stood up, finally seeing the mass of people behind Li Hanmang.

"Old Qiuguo," Tang Wenshu pressed his palms together and bowed his head in greeting.

"So it's young Tang. Haven't seen you in many years—you've already reached such an age," Old Qiuguo sighed, then gripped Li Hanmang's hand again. "You're asking about Infinite Ghost Fire—has the world suffered some calamity?"

Li Hanmang nodded and gripped those withered hands tightly: "Master Ancestor, the Six Realms are now in peril. Please enlighten us!"

Old Qiuguo slightly opened her mouth. She stepped out of the coffin and took out a walking stick, placing it in front for support. After pondering for a moment, she seemed to retrieve memories from her mind.

"All things generate and restrain each other. Infinite Ghost Fire was born with Chaos, so naturally there must be methods to extinguish it," she waved her hand, commanding everyone to gather around her.

"The world knows much about Pangu opening the heavens, but doesn't know about Nuwa creating the world. When Pangu opened heaven and earth, his body perished. It was Nuwa who opened the world and created things, giving birth to gods and transforming humans. She used supreme pure qi to forge the Jade Pure Cloud-Opening Bottle, which extinguished the ghost fire and eliminated evil spirits," Old Qiuguo said tremblingly.

"Jade Pure Cloud-Opening Bottle?" Master Feiguang pressed his palms together and looked around. "My master mentioned this bottle before his passing, saying it was merely a legend. If such a divine artifact truly existed in this world, it wouldn't have fallen to the mortal realm—people would have fought to the death for it long ago!"

"That makes sense," the Ghost Sight Sect Master pointed at Old Qiuguo. "What you speak of are all legends. No one has ever seen this bottle—how can we take it seriously?"

Old Qiuguo slowly looked at him. The Ghost Sight Sect Master suddenly felt as if something was strangling his throat. He kept retreating, his face flushing, and quickly knelt down waving his hands to show he knew his error.

Old Qiuguo snorted coldly, and only then did the constriction around his neck disappear. He coughed so hard the entire tomb chamber echoed with the sound, utterly miserable.

Li Hanmang looked at the Ghost Sight Sect Master with pity and shook her head: "Sect Master, your knowledge is still lacking. Don't look at my Master Ancestor as frail and powerless now—in her youth, she was the number one Blissful Union sword cultivator in the immortal realm, commanding wind as sword, most skilled at killing invisibly."

The Ghost Sight Sect Master was still coughing on the ground. Finally, he bowed with both hands and said hoarsely: "This... this humble one was impolite..."

Old Qiuguo grinned toothlessly, then continued: "The Jade Pure Cloud-Opening Bottle was originally Nuwa's magical artifact. After Nuwa passed away, it fell into the hands of the gods and was protected by the god clan as a sacred artifact. However, when the god clan was destroyed, Emperor Tang and Hongxi knew that once the Jade Pure Bottle fell into jianghu¹, it would certainly become an object of contention, so they disguised it as a mundane object and entrusted it to the human realm."

"As for where the bottle currently is, this old one doesn't know," Old Qiuguo said.

Ning Fuyi could feel the hand in her palm move slightly, but when she looked up at Chu Qingqiu, the other's eyes showed their usual indifference.

Perhaps she was overthinking. Ning Fuyi withdrew her gaze.

"The human realm?" Tang Wenshu said with regret. "But the human realm spans five lakes and four seas, vast and broad. Where would we search for this bottle? Old Qiuguo, can you recall anything else?"

"Yes, Master Ancestor, why don't you think some more?" Li Hanmang shook the walking stick in Old Qiuguo's hand.

"If this old one could remember, I certainly wouldn't conceal it. But this matter was ten thousand years ago after all. This old one only heard it secondhand—how could I know where exactly that bottle is hidden?" Old Qiuguo slowly shook her head.

"Could it be that besides this untraceable bottle, there's nothing else in the world that can resist Infinite Ghost Fire?" Tang Wenshu sighed deeply.

The tomb was quiet for a long time. Finally, Old Qiuguo's aged voice sounded again, but this time with some helplessness.

"There is another method. Infinite Ghost Fire can burn by relying on evil spirit power. Ordinary water can't affect it, but the divine blood of the god clan is naturally pure and might have some resistance to it."

Halfway through her words, Ning Fuyi's eyes widened. She instinctively gripped Chu Qingqiu's soft fingers tightly, squeezing them until they lost their color.

But Chu Qingqiu showed no reaction.

"Divine clan blood—didn't they say Penglai Realm are all demigods? Just capture a few to extinguish the fire!" the Ghost Sight Sect Master finally stopped coughing and looked up.

"The god clan has long been destroyed. Those so-called demigods who have been passed down for generations have long separated from their divine bodies—they're all just pretense," Old Qiuguo shook her head.

"Only those who survive to this day and truly bear pure qi are gods," she added.

Ning Fuyi didn't hear what they said afterward. Her thoughts seemed stuck on that sentence, not loud but deafening.

When Chu Qingqiu pulled her out of the tomb chamber, she realized Old Qiuguo had already returned to her coffin. Everyone exchanged complex farewells and scattered, returning to their sects to try searching for traces of the Jade Pure Cloud-Opening Bottle.

The light on the island was glaring, so bright it made one want to cry. Ning Fuyi kept gripping that soft hand tightly, squeezing it until it alternated between red and white.

"Yiyi," Chu Qingqiu said gently, tenderly removing her five fingers. "It hurts."

Only then did Ning Fuyi come to her senses and release her grip. Instead, she grasped her wrist and looked at her sideways, her eyes showing complex and obsessive emotions.

Chu Qingqiu didn't meet her gaze.

"Those who remain to this day, bearing pure qi—gods," Ning Fuyi spoke, her voice low. She gripped that wrist tighter and pulled her in front of herself. "You knew early on, didn't you?"

"I didn't know," Chu Qingqiu shook her head, her heart also in confusion. "I really didn't know."

"Though I've lived long, I don't know all things," Chu Qingqiu shook her head. "Yiyi, please calm down."

"I'm very calm," Ning Fuyi smiled with a pale face. "Now that you know, what do you plan to do? Tell them you have a divine body and once again sacrifice yourself to extinguish the fire?"

"Ning Fuyi, don't take your anger out on me," Chu Qingqiu said, breaking free from Ning Fuyi's palm.

"Besides, you said just the other day that you would accompany me."

Ning Fuyi no longer knew what expression was on her face. She only knew that sorrow and grief mixed together in her heart, making her dizzy.

"When I said I'd accompany you, I didn't mean for you to die, not for you to become a tool for the common people, having to exchange your life for everything!"

"They say all things in time have cause and effect. What kind of cause did we plant to deserve such evil fruit? I don't understand why!" Ning Fuyi kept her voice low to avoid drawing attention, but every word was an angry accusation.

"You're such a good person—why must you face death again and again? Just because you were born a god, must you bear all this? Why!"

When she said "why," her voice already carried a sob.

Chu Qingqiu was like the cool wind of a dark night, brushing away the turbid qi around her. Yet for two lifetimes, she had followed the wind but still couldn't hold onto her.

She didn't want it to be this way, and she hated that she had no way to eliminate Penglai Realm right now, to sever that evil head held high in the heavens.

"But if the ghost fire isn't extinguished, it will fulfill the evil spirit's wishes. The human realm will become purgatory, and all the living beings you see—including those who are devoted to you: Liu Wenzhu, Rong Jin, Jiuying..."

"That still has nothing to do with you," Ning Fuyi interrupted, obsessive feelings surging in her heart, wanting desperately to grasp the figure before her.

"Someone come," she suddenly said. Black smoke rose, and Han Ya landed before her. Her dark eyes looked at Ning Fuyi, then at Chu Qingqiu with furrowed brows, sensing the wrong atmosphere and not daring to speak.

"Go to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate and tell Elder Pingyao that the Divine Venerable has urgent matters and won't return to the sect for several days. Tell them to hurry and search for traces of the Jade Pure Cloud-Opening Bottle."

Han Ya bowed and said yes, then flapped her wings and left.

"Ning Fuyi, you..."

"Come back to Deterrent Hall with me," Ning Fuyi said for the first time with such a forceful tone, brooking no argument.

Deterrent Hall was peaceful and tranquil, no different from when they left. Upon entering, flowing water gurgled under the stone bridge, occasionally flashing golden light from koi scales, illuminating the hard stone walls around.

Chu Qingqiu was pulled all the way inside by Ning Fuyi. Then the great doors sealed shut, and three barriers isolated the underground palace from the world.

"Ning Fuyi, are you going to imprison me!" Chu Qingqiu heard the sound of barriers falling and angrily shook off Ning Fuyi's hand.

White Bone transformed from her palm into a jade staff, pointing at Ning Fuyi's face like a sword.

"I'm not imprisoning you," Ning Fuyi looked at her fearlessly, spreading her arms wide. "The barriers are connected to my life force. If you kill me, you can naturally leave."

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu swept white light from her palm. The sharp cold light grazed past Ning Fuyi's body, blasting the stone bridge to pieces. The koi below wagged their tails into blurs, hurriedly dodging in panic.

"You truly are something!" Chu Qingqiu was so angry her eyes reddened and her chest heaved.

"Didn't you know this long ago?" Ning Fuyi lowered her arms, her eyes cold and resolute. After speaking, she said no more and turned back to the bedchamber.

The bedchamber was pitch black. Candles lit following her footsteps, illuminating the outlines of furnishings in the room. Ning Fuyi's steps were somewhat unsteady as she slowly sat at a black stone square table.

Xi Que brought over a pot of tea and placed it on the table, saying softly: "Hall Master, you and the Divine Venerable..."

"It's nothing," Ning Fuyi said. She took the teacup, poured herself a cup of strong tea, raised her head and drank it all, trying to suppress the fear in her heart.

Fear of possibly losing Chu Qingqiu again.

Xi Que made a troubled sound of agreement and spoke: "The Divine Venerable is still standing at the door, completely lost in thought."

"I know," Ning Fuyi said glumly. She looked up: "Go make a trip to the demon cave. Find all the ancient texts you can, and send word down—tell Shang Qiu to have all demons and monsters in the demon caves search for the whereabouts of the Jade Pure Cloud-Opening Bottle."

"Once there are clues, there will be rewards for all," she said distractedly.

"Jade Pure Cloud-Opening Bottle?" Xi Que committed the name to memory and nodded. "Yes."

After Xi Que silently withdrew, Ning Fuyi stared at the flickering candlelight for a while, then took out the Divine-Demon Manual, repeatedly reading through the incomprehensible cultivation formulas, trying to find something.

But there was nothing about the Jade Pure Cloud-Opening Bottle, so she became increasingly irritated as she read, finally throwing it against the wall.

The book hit the wall with a thud, pages fluttering as it fell, accidentally touching the candle flame.

Seeing the paper about to be burned by the candle fire, Ning Fuyi was startled and instinctively flashed forward, snatching the book from the flames, placing it against her chest with lingering fear.

She was stunned for a long time, then lowered her head to open the pages again. Fortunately nothing was burned—only one page left with a scorch mark.

Ning Fuyi looked at that mark, her dark brows slightly raised. She brought the page closer to see. Under the mark were several Sanskrit phrases that Chu Qingqiu had meticulously transcribed.

"When good is considered good, this is not good. Difficulty and ease complement each other, long and short give form to each other..." she slowly read according to the Sanskrit. "The source of gods and demons both lie in a single thought. If the thought doesn't change, gods and demons can slay heaven."

What did this mean? It seemed to be just a passage of scriptural discourse, not any cultivation formula.

Even if gods and demons both originated from heaven and earth, where there's ugliness there's beauty, where there's evil there's good, where there's demons there are gods—so what?

Good and evil ultimately cannot coexist. Beauty is lovely, ugliness is evil. Gods serve the world, demons are petty. If one could be a god, who would want to become a demon?

This passage kept circling in her mind. Ning Fuyi felt like she had stepped into a strange loop, unable to find a way out. In her struggling thoughts, she almost had the sensation of qi deviation².

Fortunately, at this moment, knocking sounds arose, and she broke free from the ancient words swirling in her ears, immediately feeling as if she had emerged from water, drenched in sweat.

¹ Jianghu (江湖): The martial arts world or community

² Qi deviation (走火入魔): A dangerous condition in cultivation where one's energy goes astray, potentially leading to madness or death